STORIES OF COURAGE by Clare Gray
(A2+–B1)

INTRODUCTION

Ss first listen to a extract from *The River to Freedom* in *Stories of Courage* by Clare Gray in which a man, Matthew, is lucky in an encounter with a crocodile. Ss then read the rest of the story in which we see the man imprisoned in Sudan, escape and survive many dangers to find refuge in Bulgaria. Ss find out more about refugees and citizenship.

Supplementary Materials

WARM UP: a map or globe showing Africa and Europe
ACTIVE INVESTIGATION: internet access
SPEAKOUT: internet access
CLIL CONNECTION: dictionaries

WARM UP

Show the map, or hand out maps to Ss in groups (see Supplementary materials). Ask Ss to identify Sudan and Bulgaria. Elicit anything they know about the two countries and ask *How difficult would it be to travel from Sudan to Bulgaria without a plane?* (very) *What difficulties would someone have?* (Many possible answers as it would be long and dangerous and you would need food, shelter, etc.) Aim to get Ss thinking but don't give feedback or correct ideas.

Culture notes

About the book
Stories of Courage is a collection of eight true stories about exceptionally brave people from different parts of the world. Each courageous individual demonstrates remarkable determination; every story is inspirational. The true identity of the brave man in *The River to Freedom* cannot be disclosed. 'Matthew' is just one of the world's brave refugees in Sudan who has escaped persecution in his own country and set up a successful life abroad. He suffered in prison, but managed to run away. He travelled thousands of kilometres, eventually finding peace and freedom in a land far from his own.

Sudan
Sudan is a country that has suffered two civil wars. The conflicts also caused the deaths of around two million people from war, famine and disease. Four million people are estimated to have lost their homes or been forced to leave their towns, some multiple times, during the conflicts. The Sudanese people have endured human rights violations like slavery and mass killings and more civilians have died there than in most wars since the Second World War.

PREPARATION

THINKING ROUTINE

1

see

Focus Ss on the picture of the boat and the background picture of the people walking. Ask *What can you see? What are the people doing?* Elicit ideas but don't confirm at this stage.

ANSWERS:
1 People crowded onto a boat. People walking in single file wearing backpacks.
2 Possible answers: escaping their country, travelling.

think, wonder

Divide Ss into pairs and give them time to discuss the questions in *think* and *wonder* (see Culture note below).

Culture note

This discussion may need sensitive handling if there are Ss who are/were, or whose parents are/were, refugees. Think about how you pair Ss up, how long to spend on a topic and how to approach feedback of ideas if this applies to your class.

ANSWERS:
think
3 Possible answers: scared, excited, exhausted, hungry, sad.

wonder
4 Ss' own answers, e.g. not understanding the language or culture; leaving friends and family behind; strange food; not knowing how bureaucratic processes work; your qualifications not being recognised; hostility from people born in that country or who came there before you.

LISTENING

LISTENING PREVIEW LL6.01

Focus Ss on the title of the reading extract ***The River to Freedom*** and ask *What kind of freedom does this mean?* Do not confirm answers at this stage. (Possible answers: escape from a place or people, or the idea of travel as freedom so it's escape from the stress of life.)

Focus on the words in the glossary box and make sure Ss know that 'ache' is pronounced 'ake' so they recognise it when they hear it.

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2 LL6.01 **Tell Ss they are going to hear the beginning of a true story about an African man called Matthew. Ask *Why was he lucky this time?* Play the recording LL6.01 once or twice as needed, for Ss to answer the question.**

ANSWERS:
Because the crocodile turns away and doesn't eat him.

LL6.01 AUDIOSCRIPT

The African sun hung low in the sky and the Nile River moved slowly and quietly through the wide land. Matthew **shivered**, his clothes cold against his skin in the water. He floated silently, listening carefully for soldiers' voices. He shivered again, this time with fear. He knew they would kill him if they found him. Though his body **ached** and he was weak and hungry, he stayed still, hidden by the long grass at the side of the river. The sound of a man swimming would travel far on this quiet evening and the soldiers could be nearby. Matthew looked slowly around the dark river – straight into the narrow, yellow eyes of a crocodile!

The large, dangerous animal began swimming quickly toward him. 'I'm a dead man!' he thought. As it came closer, Matthew looked deep into its cold eyes and prepared for a painful death. Suddenly, the crocodile turned and swam away. It wasn't his first lucky escape – or his last.

Ask Ss what we know about Matthew so far. (He's being chased by soldiers. He's hungry and weak so has probably been on the run a while. He's brave.) Ask *Why is he escaping from soldiers?* (We don't know but we can either assume that he is a criminal on the run or an innocent man escaping something else, e.g. war.)

READING

3 LL6.02 **Tell Ss they're going to read the rest of Matthew's story. Allow time for them to read in silence or play the recording so they can listen and read. When they have finished, go back to the things they thought they knew about Matthew from the Listening and see what they can add. (He was escaping prison but had done nothing wrong. There was a war on – see Culture notes. He is even braver than it first seemed to escape in the way he did. He is safe now in another country.)**

COMPREHENSION

4 Focus Ss on headings a–g. Ss match the headings to the appropriate paragraph, looking for key words in the heading to match key words in the text.

ANSWERS:
1 f) The last day of normal life
2 g) A hard life
3 a) A chance for freedom
4 c) The escape
5 d) A new life

ACTIVE INVESTIGATION

5 Focus Ss on Questions 1–2 and allow time for them to research online, either at home or in class. They can work individually and compare findings as exact numbers may vary for Questions 1–2. For Question 3, they may have their own ideas and so they should just confirm or add to them by researching.

Get feedback as a whole class to check they have found more or less the same answers and ask *Where did you find the information?* (e.g. government statistics, newspapers) *Is the information reliable? How can you check?* (By comparing with other sources and following links to see where information came from.)

ANSWERS:
1 Numbers will vary year to year. Also Ss may find a difference between official and unofficial asylum seekers.
2 Answers will vary depending on current situations in the world.
3 War; political instability; persecution because of religion, political beliefs, ethnicity or sexuality; natural disasters; poverty.

SPEAKING

6 Elicit onto the board any famous refugees Ss know. Ss then choose one, or research online to add to the list and choose one of those, and answer Questions 1–4 using the internet for research. Then pair them with someone who researched a different person and they can tell their partner what they've learned.

Alternative approach

Ss work with a partner to prepare and give a presentation to the class about the famous person they have researched.

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CLIL CONNECTION

Citizenship

7 **Make the link between being a refugee and becoming a citizen of another country and explain that this is what Matthew did because being a citizen in Sudan did not give him the rights we expect to have. Ask *What rights did Matthew not have in Sudan?* (freedom, safety, a fair trial, justice)**

Ask *What do we mean by a right?* (something the government makes possible for you) *What do we mean by a responsibility?* (something you have to do for your country) Elicit the rights and responsibilities Ss already know that citizens have onto the board. Then have Ss look at the box in question 1 and use a dictionary to make sure they know the meaning of all of them.

Divide Ss into pairs to answer Questions 2–3. Get feedback as a class to check Question 2 before allowing them to move onto Question 3.

ANSWERS:

2 Rights: vote; worship according to your religion; have an education; be equal to other citizens; express your opinions; have a fair trial in court. Responsibilities: vote; pay taxes; respect the law; carry identification.

3 Ss' own answers

Homework ideas

- Ss write a magazine profile about the famous refugee they researched in Speakout.
- Ss imagine and write another extract about things that could have happened to Matthew, in the style of the crocodile story.

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